SCHUFA: Germany's Credit Score System Explained

What SCHUFA is, how your score works, how to get your free report, and what to do as a new arrival with no German credit history.

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IN SHORT

SCHUFA is Germany's main credit bureau; since 17 March 2026 its score runs from 100 to 999 points (it used to be a 0–100% Basisscore), and 776 points or more counts as excellent.

You get one free data copy per year (Datenkopie nach Art. 15 DSGVO) at meineschufa.de, and since 2026 a free online SCHUFA account — landlords instead want the paid €29.95 BonitätsCheck (Bonitätsauskunft).

New arrivals have an empty file; building a solid score via a bank account and postpaid phone contract takes about 6–12 months.

> Settled negative entries are usually deleted 3 years after the debt is paid (18 months if paid within 100 days); ordering your own report does not affect your score.

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If you've ever tried to rent an apartment in Germany, you've probably encountered the word SCHUFA. Every landlord asks for it. Most banks check it. Phone providers and car lease companies run it automatically. Understanding how it works and how to manage it as an expat is one of the most practical things you can do when settling in Germany.

Your Schufa score matters for a mortgage guide for expats and for internet and mobile contracts.

What is SCHUFA?

SCHUFA stands for **Schutzgemeinschaft für allgemeine Kreditsicherung**, roughly the "protection association for general credit security." It is Germany's main private credit bureau, founded in 1927 and now holding data on around 68 million people and 6 million businesses in Germany.

SCHUFA operates as a shared database. Banks, mobile phone providers, credit card companies, and other financial institutions report your payment behaviour to SCHUFA, and in return, they can query SCHUFA before deciding whether to extend you credit, a phone contract, or a lease. The system is designed to give lenders a picture of how reliably you pay your bills.

SCHUFA is a private company, not a government body. Its shareholders are mainly German banks and other financial institutions. This matters because your SCHUFA file is separate from tax records, Einwohnermelderegister (the residents' register), or any government database.

What data does SCHUFA hold?

SCHUFA collects data in two categories: **positive data** (things that exist but haven't gone wrong) and **negative data** (payment problems and defaults).

Positive data includes:

- German bank accounts (Girokonten) opened in your name
- Credit cards and charge cards
- Instalment loans (Ratenkredite) and overdraft facilities
- Mobile phone contracts (postpaid)
- Buy-now-pay-later agreements
- Leasing agreements for cars or equipment
- Credit enquiries made by lenders

Negative data includes:

- Missed or late payments that were formally notified
- Unpaid invoices passed to debt collection agencies
- Insolvency proceedings
- Accounts terminated by the lender due to default
- Fraud-related entries

SCHUFA does **not** hold data on your income, savings, employment status, nationality, marital status, or place of residence. Your Anmeldung address is not automatically shared with SCHUFA, though if you open a bank account at your registered address, that address may appear in your file.

The SCHUFA score explained

Since 17 March 2026, SCHUFA uses a new score on a scale of **100 to 999 points**. It replaces the old percentage Basisscore (0–100%) and is based on 12 published criteria. The higher the score, the lower the perceived credit risk.

SCHUFA sorts scores into classes:

- **776 to 999 points (excellent):** low risk compared with the average person
- **709 to 775 points (good):** average risk
- **642 to 708 points (acceptable):** slightly higher risk; some lenders may ask for more information
- **Below 642 points (sufficient):** higher risk; some landlords and lenders will decline
- **No score (insufficient):** open payment defaults are on file

Most people land in the top class: according to SCHUFA, **more than 60%** of people score 776 points or more, and that score will satisfy almost every landlord or lender. Points and percentages cannot be converted one to one (a 98% Basisscore is not automatically 980 points), so ignore old percentage tables.

SCHUFA now publishes the 12 criteria and the points each can earn. The main factors that affect your score are: the number and type of credit accounts you hold, the length of your credit history, your payment behaviour, and the number of recent credit enquiries. Having many accounts or recent hard enquiries can lower your score temporarily even if you've never missed a payment.

> **Your score is not live, and not every lender uses the new one yet.** It reflects the data on file when it is calculated, so a resolved negative entry may take a while to show. Some companies still use older percentage or industry scores, and SCHUFA has not named an end date for them.

Why it matters as an expat

In Germany, your SCHUFA record affects far more than just bank loans. Here is where you will encounter it:

- **Renting an apartment:** Almost every private landlord and housing company asks for a SCHUFA report as part of the rental application. A missing or bad SCHUFA is one of the most common reasons expats are turned down for apartments, even when they have the income to afford the rent.
- **Opening a bank account:** Some banks, particularly traditional banks, run a SCHUFA check before opening a current account. Digital banks like N26 and DKB tend to be more lenient, but they still check.

- **Mobile phone contracts:** Postpaid mobile contracts (where you pay monthly rather than topping up prepaid credit) require a SCHUFA check. If your file is empty or negative, the provider may decline and offer you a prepaid SIM instead.
- **Car leasing and financing:** Any financing agreement (car loans, leasing contracts, hire purchase) involves a SCHUFA check. A good score can also affect the interest rate you are offered.
- **Instalment purchases:** Large purchases financed in instalments (furniture, electronics) require a SCHUFA check at point of sale.
- **Internet and utility contracts:** Some internet providers and energy companies run SCHUFA checks before setting up a contract.

The new arrival problem

When you first arrive in Germany, you will have no SCHUFA entry at all. This is called a **"thin file"**: you are not a credit risk, you simply don't exist in the system yet.

The counterintuitive reality is that **no SCHUFA history can be almost as problematic as a bad one** for certain landlords and lenders. Some landlords specifically filter for this: if you have no SCHUFA entry, they don't know what to make of you, and in a competitive rental market, they'll prefer an applicant with an established, clean German credit file.

This is one of the more frustrating aspects of arriving in Germany. You need an apartment to get your Anmeldung. You need your Anmeldung to open a bank account. You need a bank account to start building a SCHUFA history. And landlords want a SCHUFA score before they'll give you the apartment. The loop is tight.

The good news: a thin file is not a negative entry. Most landlords will accept a statement that you have no German credit history combined with proof of income: salary slips, an employment contract, or a letter from your employer. Corporate housing, serviced apartments, and international relocation agencies often help bridge this gap for the first few months.

How to build your SCHUFA score as a new arrival

The fastest way to establish a positive SCHUFA file is to open financial relationships that are reported to SCHUFA and then manage them well.

1. Open a German bank account

Opening a German Girokonto (current account) is the single most important first step. Most German bank accounts are reported to SCHUFA, and having an active account in your name is a foundational positive entry. Digital banks like N26, DKB, and ING are the easiest to open as a new arrival. Many allow you to open an account with just your passport, without needing an Anmeldung first. Get an account as soon as you arrive. See our German bank account guide for a full comparison.

2. Get a mobile phone contract

Signing a postpaid mobile phone contract (a monthly plan, not prepaid) creates a positive SCHUFA entry once the provider reports it. Pay the bill on time every month. Providers like Telekom, Vodafone, O2, and many MVNOs will run a SCHUFA check. With a thin file, you may be asked to pay a deposit, but approval is usually given.

3. Use a credit card responsibly

Some German banks offer credit cards that report to SCHUFA. Use the card for regular purchases and pay the balance in full each month. Carrying a balance is not necessary to build your score; consistent use and on-time payment is what matters. Avoid applying for multiple cards at once, as each application creates a hard enquiry in your file.

4. Avoid closing accounts unnecessarily

The length of your credit history is a factor in your score. A bank account you've held for three years is more valuable to your score than a new one, all else being equal. Don't close old accounts just because you're not using them actively.

5. Be patient

It typically takes **6 to 12 months** of responsible financial activity to build a solid SCHUFA score. There are no shortcuts. Negative entries usually stay on your file for **three years** after the underlying debt is settled (18 months in some cases, see below). Building a clean history from the start is much easier than repairing a damaged one.

How to get your SCHUFA report

You are entitled to see all data SCHUFA holds on you. There are two ways to do this, and they serve different purposes.

The free report: Datenkopie nach Art. 15 DSGVO

Under Article 15 of the GDPR (Datenschutz-Grundverordnung / DSGVO), you have the right to request a free copy of all data any company holds on you, including SCHUFA. This is called the **Datenkopie** or **Selbstauskunft**.

To request it:

1. Go to meineschufa.de
2. Look for the option labelled **"Datenkopie nach Art. 15 DSGVO"** (it is free)
3. You will need to verify your identity, typically by providing your name, date of birth, address, and uploading a copy of your ID
4. SCHUFA sends the report by post to your registered address. This takes approximately **2 to 4 weeks**

You can request this once per year at no cost. Use it to check what SCHUFA holds on you and to identify any errors in your file.

Since March 2026 you can also look at your score for free in a SCHUFA account at app.schufa.de. You have to verify your identity first, for example with a PIN letter sent by post. Make sure you sign up for the free account, not a paid product.

> **The free Datenkopie is for your eyes only.** It is a detailed data dump, not formatted for landlords or lenders. Do not hand this to a landlord. They will not know how to read it and may not accept it. What they actually want is the paid Bonitätsauskunft (see below).

The paid report: Bonitätsauskunft

The **Bonitätsauskunft** is a formatted, official creditworthiness certificate that shows your SCHUFA score in the way lenders and landlords expect to see it. It costs **€29.95** (one-time; SCHUFA now sells it as the BonitätsCheck) and is available as an instant PDF download from meineschufa.de after creating an account and completing identity verification.

This is the document landlords ask for when they say "we need your SCHUFA." It includes:

- Your score in points
- A traffic-light style creditworthiness indicator
- A summary statement suitable for third parties
- A 60-day period during which you can share the PDF with landlords and other third parties

There are also paid subscriptions (meineSCHUFA kompakt starts at €4.95/month) that add alerts when your file changes. With the free account for viewing your score, you only need one if you want those alerts.

What landlords actually want

When a landlord in Germany asks for "a SCHUFA," they almost always mean the **Bonitätsauskunft**: the paid, formatted PDF that shows a clear score and creditworthiness summary. They do not want the free Datenkopie.

The report should be **recent**. The BonitätsCheck PDF can be shared for 60 days, so if you are actively flat-hunting, download a fresh one at the start of your search and keep it as a PDF ready to send. Include it in your rental application package alongside:

- Your last three salary slips (Gehaltsabrechnungen)
- A copy of your passport
- A Mietschuldenfreiheitsbescheinigung (letter from previous landlord confirming no rent arrears), if you have one
- Your employment contract or a letter from your employer confirming your position and salary

If your SCHUFA file is thin (you're a new arrival with no German credit history), be upfront about it. Include a brief cover note explaining that you recently arrived in Germany and have not yet established a German credit history, and include as much income documentation as possible. Some landlords will appreciate the honesty more than they would appreciate a missing document.

Hard enquiries vs SCHUFA-neutral enquiries

Not all SCHUFA enquiries are equal. There are two types, and understanding the difference can protect your score.

Hard enquiries (score-affecting)

A **Kreditanfrage** (credit enquiry) is a hard pull. It is recorded in your SCHUFA file and can lower your score. Hard enquiries occur when you formally apply for a loan, a credit card, a mortgage, or in some cases a phone contract. Multiple hard enquiries in a short period look like financial stress to lenders, even if you're just shopping around.

SCHUFA-neutral enquiries (score-neutral)

A **SCHUFA-neutrale Anfrage** or **Konditionsanfrage** (condition check) is a soft pull. It allows a lender to check your creditworthiness and give you an indicative rate or offer without leaving a hard enquiry in your file. If you are comparing loan offers from multiple banks, always ask whether the enquiry is a Konditionsanfrage or a Kreditanfrage before proceeding. A good lender will always offer the neutral version first.

> **Ordering your own report does not affect your score.** A landlord normally does not query SCHUFA directly. They ask you to hand over your BonitätsCheck, so there is no enquiry from the landlord side.

Disputing errors in your SCHUFA file

SCHUFA files sometimes contain errors. Common problems include:

- Negative entries that belong to someone with a similar name
- Old debts that have been paid but are still showing as outstanding
- Accounts that were never opened by you (identity fraud)
- Entries that should have been deleted after the statutory retention period
- Incorrectly recorded payment defaults

If you find an error in your file, here is how to dispute it:

1. **Request your free Datenkopie** first so you can see exactly what SCHUFA holds on you

2. **Contact the company that submitted the entry** (not SCHUFA directly). SCHUFA only records what its member companies report. If the entry is wrong, the original company must correct or delete it
3. **Write a formal objection (Widerspruch)** to the company, citing the specific entry and why it is incorrect. Request that they instruct SCHUFA to correct or delete the entry
4. **Write to SCHUFA directly** at the same time. Send your objection to SCHUFA's consumer services team at: SCHUFA Holding AG, Privatkunden Servicecenter, Postfach 10 34 41, 50474 Cologne. You can also use the online dispute form at meineschufa.de
5. If the company refuses to correct a legitimate error, you can file a complaint with the **Datenschutzbehörde** (data protection authority) in your state via bfdi.bund.de. This is free and companies take it seriously

SCHUFA is legally required to investigate disputes and respond within one month. Legitimate errors are corrected. If a negative entry is valid but the underlying debt has been paid, it will remain on your file but will be marked as settled, and will be deleted after three years from the date of settlement.

Two rulings of the European Court of Justice strengthened your rights: on 7 December 2023 (C-634/21) it held that a score used to decide on a contract counts as an automated decision, and on 27 February 2025 (C-203/22) it confirmed you can ask how a score was calculated. If a company turns you down because of your score, ask them whether the score was decisive, then ask SCHUFA how it was calculated.

How long do entries stay on your file?

- **Paid debts and settled defaults:** deleted 3 years after settlement, or after 18 months if you paid within 100 days of the report, no other negative data is stored and there is no insolvency or debtor-register entry
- **Unpaid defaults reported by companies:** deleted 3 years after the entry date, even if still unpaid (but the creditor can sue separately)
- **Credit enquiries:** visible for 12 months, deleted after 12 months
- **Active accounts:** remain while the account is open, deleted roughly 3 years after the account is closed
- **Debt discharge (Restschuldbefreiung):** deleted 6 months after the court decision, following the ECJ ruling of 7 December 2023 (C-26/22 and C-64/22)

Other credit bureaus in Germany

SCHUFA is by far the most widely used credit bureau in Germany, but it is not the only one. Other agencies exist and some lenders or landlords may use them instead of or in addition to SCHUFA.

- **Boniversum** (part of the Creditreform group): used by some retail lenders and insurance companies
- **CRIF Bürgel**: used in the B2B space and by some consumer lenders; also holds data on individuals
- **Infoscore Consumer Data (ICD)** (an Experian company): holds data primarily on negative payment history; often used by utilities and telecoms companies
- **Arvato Financial Solutions**: used by some e-commerce and mail-order companies

Each of these agencies is covered by the same GDPR-based right to a free annual self-disclosure. If you suspect a negative entry exists somewhere other than SCHUFA, you can request your file from each of them separately at no cost.

Tips for new arrivals with no SCHUFA history

If you have just arrived in Germany and your SCHUFA file is empty, here is a practical action plan:

- **Open a German bank account immediately.** This is your first positive SCHUFA entry and unlocks everything that follows
- **Get a postpaid mobile contract as soon as you can.** Even a basic plan works. Pay by direct debit from your German account
- **Do not apply for multiple financial products at once.** Space out applications over several weeks to avoid multiple hard enquiries landing at the same time
- **Use your income documentation.** For apartment applications, a strong salary, a permanent employment contract, and three months of salary slips can compensate for an empty SCHUFA. Present these proactively
- **Consider a Bürgschaft:** a guarantor arrangement where a third party (sometimes an employer or a financial service) guarantees your rent payments. Some relocation agencies and international employers offer this to new hires
- **Request your free Datenkopie after 6 months.** By this point you should have some positive entries. Check that they are recorded correctly and that no

errors have crept in

- **Don't panic about the Bonitätsauskunft cost.** The €29.95 one-time cost for a formatted report is worth it if you're actively apartment hunting. Think of it as part of your moving costs

Sources

- New score, scale and free access: Verbraucherzentrale, Neuer Schufa-Score
- Score classes: SCHUFA, score classes
- Information products: SCHUFA FAQ; BonitätsCheck price and validity: meineSCHUFA
- Debt discharge storage period: ECJ, C-26/22 and C-64/22
- Storage of settled defaults: Stiftung Warentest on the BGH ruling

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